

Position Control of a Two-Propeller Aeropendulum: A Comparison Between Voltage and Current Actuation

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Abstract

This paper presents the design, modeling, and experimental validation of a low-cost twin-rotor aeropendulum testbed to evaluate the impact of low-level actuation on aerospace control systems. Standard brushless propulsion units traditionally drive the plant via voltage-equivalent signals (PWM), introducing severe dynamic non-linearities and thrust asymmetries. To address these issues, we propose and compare two low-level operational frameworks: a conventional equivalent voltage-driven scheme and a software-based virtual estimated current loop. Both frameworks are benchmarked under classical parallel PID and adaptive hybrid Fuzzy-PID position controllers. Experimental results demonstrate that the virtual current loop successfully linearizes the actuation channel, offering superior dynamic damping and reducing the control energy index (ISSC) by up to 70% compared to the voltage-driven approach. Under external disturbances, the current-driven paradigm exhibits enhanced rejection capabilities and superior steady-state precision. Furthermore, while the current-driven Fuzzy-PID achieves the best performance-to-energy trade-off for positive setpoints, the conventional PID with virtual current actuation proves to be the most balanced and reliable strategy at negative operating points.

Keywords: Aeropendulum, Actuation dynamics, Virtual current loop, Fuzzy-PID control, Energy efficiency.

1 Introduction

Control systems play a central role in the advancement of modern technologies by ensuring precision, stability, and operational efficiency even in the face of disturbances and severe dynamic conditions. However, translating abstract mathematical models encountered in academic settings into real-world solutions requires a rigorous alignment between theory and experimental validation—a

connection that characterizes a persistent pedagogical and technical challenge in the development of new technologies. Aiming to mitigate this gap between academia and the practical demands of industry, recent investigations, such as those conducted by Antunes et al. [1], propose restructuring technical learning through methodologies based on practical and interdisciplinary projects. This approach is grounded in the strategic use of didactic platforms and testbeds, which emerge as a

fundamental link in control engineering by offering a safe, replicable, and low-cost environment to evaluate the performance of new algorithms before their effective transition to high-complexity applications.

Among the real-world applications requiring high technical rigor, Unmanned Aerial Vehicles (UAVs) stand out. These multi-rotor platforms rely on robust control strategies to guarantee flight stability, precise trajectory tracking, and external disturbance rejection across diverse sectors, including precision agriculture [2] and environmental monitoring [3]. To advance UAV autonomy, recent literature has focused heavily on high-level navigation and guidance control loops. For instance, real-time collision avoidance strategies using velocity constraints have been validated via augmented reality setups [4], tube-based Model Predictive Control (MPC) has been explored for suspended load transportation in ROS/Gazebo environments [5], and model-free Integral Reinforcement Learning (IRL) has been proposed for multi-quadrotor formation flight [6]. Additionally, fuzzy adaptive feedback linearization [7] and particle swarm optimization-tuned sliding mode control [8] have been investigated to handle actuator faults. However, directly evaluating such algorithms on physical aerial platforms presents substantial risks: crash hazards, accelerated electromechanical wear, high cost of motion-capture tracking infrastructure, and embedded microcontroller computational constraints make early-stage experimental testing risky and often unfeasible. To overcome these practical constraints, laboratory testbeds provide a strategic alternative for evaluating aerospace dynamics. Among them, the aeropendulum is particularly effective. It consists of a rotational arm constrained to a single degree of freedom driven by a propulsion assembly, faithfully reproducing the fundamental thrust-torque-angle interactions present in rotary-wing aircraft [9, 10]. Consequently, the aeropendulum enables safe and replicable investigation of stability, transient dynamics, and disturbance rejection.

However, the practical effectiveness of high-level control algorithms strictly depends on low-level actuator performance. In propulsion systems based on DC or BLDC motors driven by commercial Electronic Speed Controllers (ESCs), the

low-level interface typically operates by mapping the control variable into a voltage signal via Pulse-Width Modulation (PWM) [9, 10]. Although simple to implement, voltage-driven actuation introduces severe non-linearities stemming from back-electromotive force (back-EMF), thermal resistance variations, and rotor static friction deadbands. Because the aerodynamic thrust and torque governing the plant dynamics derive directly from the electromechanical torque, which bears a linear relationship with electrical current rather than voltage, implementing a current control loop emerges as a compelling alternative to linearize the actuation channel and accelerate transient response.

To bridge this gap, the present work adopts the twin-rotor aeropendulum as an experimental investigation platform. The main contributions of this study are summarized as follows:

1. Development and experimental characterization of a software-based virtual current-estimation loop for low-cost BLDC propulsion units, eliminating the need for extra physical current sensors;
2. Quantitative comparison between equivalent voltage-driven and virtual current-driven paradigms under classical parallel Proportional-Integral-Derivative (PID) and adaptive hybrid Fuzzy-PID architectures;
3. Comprehensive experimental validation under setpoint regulation and external disturbance rejection, mapping the energy efficiency (ISSC) and transient stability boundaries of each actuation framework.

The remainder of this paper is organized as follows: Section 2 details the mathematical dynamics of the twin-rotor aeropendulum. Section 3 presents the experimental setup and parameter identification. Section 4 describes the voltage and current actuation frameworks. Section 5 presents the design of the classical parallel PID and adaptive Fuzzy-PID controllers. Section 6 discusses the experimental results, and Section 7 concludes the paper.

2 Mathematical modeling

The twin-rotor aeropendulum is modeled as a single-degree-of-freedom rotational system operating in the vertical plane about a fixed, low-friction

pivot. The fundamental physical law governing this motion is Newton's second law for rotation, which establishes that the rate of change of angular momentum of a rigid body is equal to the net external torque applied to the system. In this context, the net external torque represents the algebraic sum of the active aerodynamic thrust generated by the motors, the restoring torque due to gravity, and the resistive damping torque from mechanical friction. This resultant torque is directly proportional to the angular acceleration $\ddot{\theta}(t)$, with the constant of proportionality being the total mass moment of inertia J , as expressed in Eq. 1.

$$\sum \tau_i(t) = J\alpha(t) = J\ddot{\theta}(t) \quad (1)$$

where J represents the total mass moment of inertia of the rod-motor assembly about its fixed axis of rotation, and $\alpha(t)$ is the angular acceleration. The term $\ddot{\theta}(t)$ serves as an alternative representation of this same angular acceleration, expressing it mathematically as the second-order derivative of the angular displacement $\theta(t)$ with respect to time ($\ddot{\theta}(t) = \frac{d^2\theta(t)}{dt^2}$), where $\theta(t)$ is the angular displacement relative to the vertical equilibrium position.

To model the system effectively, these torques are conceptually divided into two distinct components: the passive and the active propulsion. The passive dynamics represent the natural behavior of the standard pendulum, characterized by gravity and friction, which inherently act to restore the system to its equilibrium position or dissipate its energy. Conversely, the active dynamics consist of the propulsion forces generated by the twin rotors, which act as the control input responsible for overcoming these natural restoring forces to drive and manipulate the pendulum's motion.

Consequently, the governing differential equations are derived by first analyzing the standard passive pendulum behavior and subsequently incorporating the effects of the active external forces. The spatial distribution of these forces, the coordinate systems, and the geometric constraints defining this combined interaction are schematically illustrated in Fig. 1.

The structural setup is modeled as a mass m concentrated at the tip of a rigid rod of length

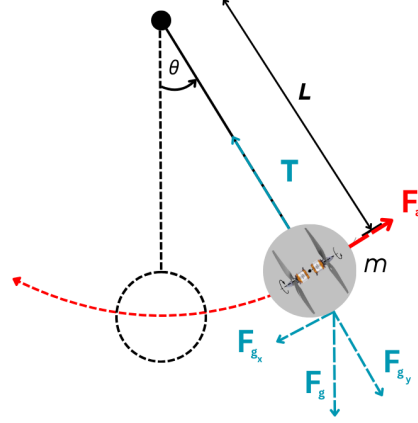


Fig. 1: Schematic diagram of the aeropendulum system.

L , deflected by an angular displacement θ relative to the vertical equilibrium plane, which is induced in the aeropendulum by external forces through the applied force F_a . The gravitational force $F_g = m_{\text{total}}g$, where g denotes the acceleration of gravity, acting on the center of mass is decomposed into two orthogonal components: the radial force $F_{g_v} = m_{\text{total}}g \cos \theta$, which acts along the longitudinal axis of the rod and is counter-balanced by the internal structural tension force T , and the tangential force $F_{g_x} = m_{\text{total}}g \sin \theta$. This tangential component acts perpendicularly to the rod, consistently pulling the system back toward the stable vertical rest position ($\theta = 0^\circ$). By taking the pivot as the rotational origin and applying the principle of superposition to all coincident perpendicular effects, the dynamic torque balance equation is expressed as:

$$\tau_m(t) + \tau_r(t) + \tau_a(t) = J\ddot{\theta}(t) \quad (2)$$

where $\tau_m(t)$ represents the active net propulsive torque generated by the twin-propeller assembly at the tip, defined by the operational difference between the front and rear actuators ($\tau_m(t) = \tau_{m1}(t) - \tau_{m2}(t)$). The term $\tau_r(t)$ is the gravitational restoring torque directly derived from the tangential force component shown in the schematic diagram, defined as $\tau_r(t) = -LF_{g_x} = -Lm_{\text{total}}g \sin \theta(t)$, where the negative sign denotes its restorative nature opposing the angular displacement. Finally, $\tau_a(t)$ is the non-conservative aerodynamic drag torque that models the atmospheric fluid resistance opposing the motion of the rod through the air, given by:

$$\tau_a(t) = -b\dot{\theta}(t) \quad (3)$$

where b denotes the rotational viscous damping coefficient and $\dot{\theta}(t)$ represents the instantaneous angular velocity.

The structural resistance to change in its rotational state, quantified by the total moment of inertia J about the rotation axis, must also be parameterized. This value is determined by combining the continuous mass distribution of the homogeneous rigid rod and the discrete masses of the two actuators located at its tip. Assuming a uniform mass distribution along the rod of length L and mass m_{haste} , and modeling the two BLDC motors as point masses of value m_{motor} located at a distance L from the pivot, the total equivalent moment of inertia is established via superposition as:

$$J = L^2 \left(\frac{1}{3}m_{\text{haste}} + 2m_{\text{motor}} \right) \quad (4)$$

Once all individual torque components acting on the mechanical structure and the geometric parameters are explicitly defined, they can be directly substituted into the general mechanical balance represented in Eq. (2). Consequently, the full non-linear second-order ordinary differential equation that governs the twin-rotor aeropendulum dynamic behavior is obtained:

$$L^2 \left(\frac{1}{3}m_{\text{haste}} + 2m_{\text{motor}} \right) \ddot{\theta}(t) + b\dot{\theta}(t) + Lm_{\text{total}}g \sin \theta(t) = \tau_{m1}(t) - \tau_{m2}(t) \quad (5)$$

For the development of classical linear control architectures, the non-linear operating region can be linearized around the stable vertical equilibrium position ($\theta = 0^\circ$). Utilizing the small-angle Taylor approximation ($\sin \theta \approx \theta$), the fundamental expression reduces to a linear ordinary differential equation. By assuming that the structural lumped parameters of the passive pendulum can be aggregated, the gravitational torque constant K_g is defined as:

$$K_g = Lm_{\text{total}}g \quad (6)$$

where m_{total} represents the total mass of the pendulum assembly, L is the distance from the pivot to the center of mass, and g is the acceleration due

to gravity. Within this context, the simplified representation of the equation can be expressed as in Eq. (7):

$$J\ddot{\theta}(t) + b\dot{\theta}(t) + K_g\theta(t) = \tau_{m1}(t) - \tau_{m2}(t) \quad (7)$$

Assuming zero initial mechanical conditions ($\theta(0) = 0$ and $\dot{\theta}(0) = 0$), the application of the Laplace transform to this model maps the dynamics directly into the complex frequency s -domain. Ultimately, the open-loop transfer function $G(s)$, which represents the system's open-loop equation and establishes the dynamic relationship between the net propulsive torque input and the resulting angular position output $\Theta(s)$, is rigorously derived as:

$$G(s) = \frac{\Theta(s)}{T_{m1}(s) - T_{m2}(s)} = \frac{1}{Js^2 + bs + K_g} \quad (8)$$

3 Experimental platform and parameter identification

To evaluate the mathematical formulations and validate the proposed control strategies, a dedicated experimental testbed was developed and utilized in this work. The physical apparatus consists of a twin-rotor aeropendulum framework, illustrated in Fig. 2, designed for the study and benchmark of non-linear control techniques.

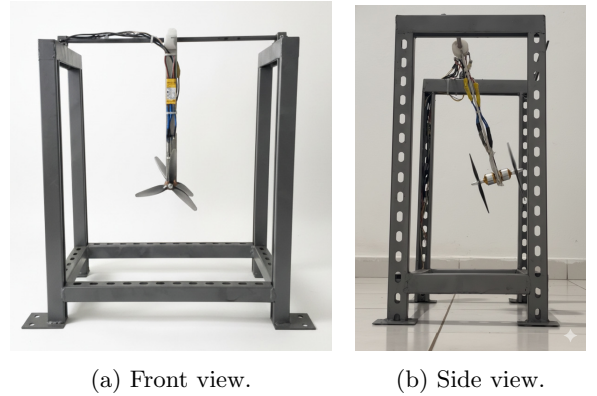


Fig. 2: The developed twin-rotor aeropendulum experimental platform from front and side perspectives.

The mechanical assembly isolates the plant's movement to a single rotational degree of freedom within the vertical plane. The main structural components, geometric constraints, and the instrumentation infrastructure are detailed below.

3.1 Mechanical and Hardware Architecture

The structural support consists of a rigid frame that holds the primary rotational shaft. To minimize frictional losses and guarantee that the plant dynamics are predominantly driven by the active aerodynamic inputs, the mechanical assembly is coupled to the fixed frame through low-friction bearings.

The primary physical and operational characteristics of the embedded subsystems are defined as follows:

- **Propulsion Subsystem:** Actuation is provided by two A2212/13T Brushless DC (BLDC) motors mounted back-to-back at the lower tip of a rigid aluminum rod ($L = 0.515$ m). Each motor is coupled to a $7 \times 4 \times 3$ polycarbonate tri-blade propeller. This assembly converts the digital control commands into active differential thrust forces perpendicular to the longitudinal axis of the rod.
- **Processing and Control Unit:** The computational core is driven by an ATmega2560 microcontroller (Arduino Mega platform). This unit is responsible for executing the real-time digital filtering routines, processing the control laws, and generating the independent high-resolution Pulse Width Modulation (PWM) signals dispatched to the Electronic Speed Controllers (ESCs). The control loop runs at a fixed sampling period, and data communication with the host computer is established via a bidirectional USB/Serial interface.
- **Sensors and Interface Subsystems:** The angular position $\theta(t)$ is acquired through a high-precision rotary potentiometer attached directly to the main pivot axis, selected due to its high linearity and noise immunity.
- **Power Supply Unit:** To ensure voltage stability and satisfy the strict current demands during high-acceleration transients, the entire platform is powered by a regulated 10 V, 30 A switched-mode power supply (SMPS).

- **Supervisory and Graphical User Interface (GUI):** A dedicated telemetry and supervisory software system was developed to mediate the experimental verification procedures. Operating over the bidirectional serial communication channel, this graphical interface allows the real-time configuration of setpoints and control parameters while simultaneously logging the estimated variables, sensor measurements, and actuator efforts for post-processing and dynamic analysis.

3.2 System Parameter Identification

Based on the physical construction and geometric synthesis of the prototype, the core structural and dynamic variables of the system were successfully determined. The mass elements and physical lengths were measured directly from the experimental apparatus, while parameters such as the total mass moment of inertia (J) and the experimental rotational viscous damping coefficient (b) were obtained through analytical formulations and free-oscillation dynamic tests, respectively.

The complete set of identified physical constants and operational parameters that govern the aeropendulum dynamics is consolidated in Table 1.

Table 1: Physical and identified parameters of the developed aeropendulum platform

Parameter	Value	Unit
Motor mass ($m_1 = m_2$)	0.052	kg
Rod mass (m_{haste})	0.100	kg
Total moment of inertia (J)	0.0173	kg·m ²
Viscous damping coefficient (b)	0.3944	N·m·s/rad
Acceleration of gravity (g)	9.8	m/s ²
Rod length (L)	0.36	m

4 Input signal interpretation and actuation dynamics

In phenomenological modeling, the input is conventionally defined by the pure net aerodynamic torque developed by the propulsion units. However, from a practical control systems perspective, the actuators cannot be directly driven by a torque command. Instead, they must be excited via voltage or current variables. This section establishes

the mathematical and experimental formulations for two distinct actuation paradigms: voltage-based equivalent actuation and estimated current-based actuation. These formulations redefine the open-loop plant inputs, establishing the basis for the comparative analysis.

4.1 Voltage-Based Actuation Dynamics

The operation of Brushless DC (BLDC) motors relies on the electromagnetic interaction between the stator windings and the permanent magnet rotor. The fundamental torque generation is structurally governed by the motor torque constant (K_t), which linearly relates the mechanical torque to the armature current (i_a):

$$\tau(t) = K_t i_a(t) \quad (9)$$

where K_t is the motor torque constant, which is inversely proportional to the motor velocity constant (K_v , specified by the manufacturer as 1000 RPM/V for the actuators utilized in this platform) according to the structural relation:

$$K_t = \frac{60}{2\pi K_v} \approx 0.00955 \text{ Nm/A} \quad (10)$$

To establish a direct practical relationship between the applied terminal voltage (V) and the resulting torque (τ), this work proposes an experimental characterization based on steady-state equilibrium conditions. Under this framework, we propose that the armature current $i_a(t)$ can be correlated to the structural angular displacement $\theta(t)$ attained by the aeropendulum through an empirical proportionality coefficient K_{fi} :

$$i_a(t) = K_{fi} \theta(t) \quad (11)$$

Concurrently, we propose a secondary linear relationship to link the steady-state angular displacement to the equivalent average terminal voltage ($V(t)$) applied to the Electronic Speed Controllers (ESCs). This correlation is defined by the coefficient K_{fv} as follows:

$$\theta(t) = K_{fv} V(t) \quad (12)$$

By combining these proposed steady-state relations, the active torque produced by an isolated motor can be coupled to its terminal voltage input through a lumped equivalent voltage-to-torque gain ($K_{\text{equivalent}}$):

By substituting (12) into (11), and the result into the fundamental torque relation (9), the active torque produced by an isolated motor can be directly coupled to its terminal voltage input through a lumped equivalent voltage-to-torque gain ($K_{\text{equivalent}}$):

$$\tau(t) = K_t K_{fi} K_{fv} V(t) = K_{\text{equivalent}} V(t) \quad (13)$$

To parameterize this model for the bidirectional setup, systematic experimental calibration procedures were conducted. Specific Pulse Width Modulation (PWM) duty cycles were applied stepwise to the front and rear actuators. The corresponding armature current, equivalent terminal voltage, and steady-state angular deflections were recorded.

Linear regression algorithms were applied to the experimental curves, mapping the correlation parameters. The calculated gains K_{fi} , K_{fv} , and the resulting lumped $K_{\text{equivalent}}$ parameters for both propulsion units are consolidated in Table 2.

Table 2: Static calibration parameters for voltage actuation

Actuator	K_{fi} (A/°)	K_{fv} (°/V)	$K_{\text{equivalent}}$ (Nm/V)
Front	0.053252	8.26146	0.00420
Rear	-0.121940	-5.11253	0.00595

Thus, by applying the algebraic difference between the independent actuators, the net voltage-driven propulsive torque command is defined as $\tau_{m1}(t) - \tau_{m2}(t) = K_{\text{equivalent},1} V_1(t) - K_{\text{equivalent},2} V_2(t)$.

4.2 Current-Based Actuation Dynamics

Unlike the voltage paradigm where torque coupling is indirect and relies on multi-stage linear approximations, current-based actuation leverages the direct, uncoupled physical relationship between armature current and torque expressed in Eq. (9). Actuating the plant via current provides a more linear control loop, as it inherently

diminishes the back-electromotive force (Back-EMF) variations and armature resistance thermal dependencies.

Since the experimental platform lacks integrated real-time physical current sensors on its embedded hardware, a virtual current sensing loop was developed in software. To establish this sensorless framework, a preliminary steady-state empirical characterization was executed to map the relationship between the applied control variable and the resulting armature current.

Through systematic experimental trials, a mapping was conducted to characterize the relationship between the electrical current consumed and the applied pulse-width modulation signal for each propulsion unit. By applying a linear approximation to the gathered experimental steady-state data, this behavior was mathematically modeled as:

$$I(t) = aPWM(t) + b \quad (14)$$

where a and b denote the empirical slope and offset coefficients, respectively, obtained through linear regression. The resulting parametric values for each actuator are summarized in Table 3.

Table 3: Identified PWM-to-Current calibration functions

Actuator	Function $I(t) = aPWM(t) + b$
Front	$I_{\text{ref}} = 0.006427PWM_1(t) - 7.139481$
Rear	$I_{\text{ref}} = 0.007061PWM_2(t) - 7.643550$

For the physical embedded implementation, this mapping is inverted inside the processing unit to establish the virtual current loop. The software execution framework processes the demanded reference current (I_{ref}) for each motor and maps it into a corresponding digital command through the following static inversion sequence:

1. The algorithm takes the desired current variable, $I_{\text{ref}}(t)$, which acts as the intermediate control input for the actuation subsystem.
2. The software execution loop applies the analytical inverse of the experimentally identified linear functions to convert this reference current into its corresponding digital PWM duty

cycle:

$$PWM(t) = \frac{I_{\text{ref}}(t) - b}{a} \quad (15)$$

where a and b represent the specific empirical parameters of the respective actuator, as consolidated in Table 3.

3. The computed duty cycle is directly dispatched to the microprocessor internal timers to synthesize the physical hardware signal that drives the ESCs.

This procedure implements a virtual current loop entirely in software, simulating the behavior of a physical current-driven actuator without the need for real-time sensing infrastructure.

This methodology successfully implements an indirect virtual current loop in software, replicating the performance of a cascaded hardware control topology without requiring real-time physical current sensing infrastructure.

5 Control system design

This work proposes and evaluates two distinct control paradigms to regulate the angular position of the twin-rotor aeropendulum: a classical parallel PID controller and an intelligent hybrid Fuzzy-PID controller. Both architectures are independently implemented and compared under both voltage and virtual current actuation frameworks, mapping the performance boundaries of each combination.

5.1 Classical PID Control Design and Tuning

5.2 Classical Parallel PID Controller Synthesis

The position control system is structured around a classical parallel PID topology. The controller processes the real-time angular position tracking error $e(t) = \theta_{\text{ref}}(t) - \theta(t)$ to generate a scalar control action $u(t)$. In the Laplace domain, the transfer function of the parallel PID controller $C(s)$ is expressed as:

$$C(s) = \frac{U(s)}{E(s)} = K_p + \frac{K_i}{s} + K_d s \quad (16)$$

where K_p , K_i , and K_d represent the proportional, integral, and derivative gains, respectively. The resulting control variable $U(s)$ is dispatched

as a differential actuation command between the front (actuator 1) and rear (actuator 2) propulsion units to generate the net propulsive moment required for angular displacement.

The synthesis leverages the open-loop transfer functions derived for current actuation ($G_I(s)$) and equivalent voltage actuation ($G_V(s)$), expressed respectively as:

$$G_I(s) = \frac{\Theta(s)}{I_{m1}(s) - I_{m2}(s)} = \frac{K_t/J}{s^2 + \frac{b}{J}s + \frac{K_g}{J}} \quad (17)$$

$$G_V(s) = \frac{\Theta(s)}{V_1(s) - V_2(s)} = \frac{(K_1 + K_2)/J}{s^2 + \frac{b}{J}s + \frac{K_g}{J}} \quad (18)$$

In Eq. (17), the denominator term $\Delta I(s) = I_{m1}(s) - I_{m2}(s)$ represents the net differential armature current between the front (I_{m1}) and rear (I_{m2}) propulsion units. Because the physical platform lacks embedded hardware current sensors, this differential current command $U(s) = \Delta I(s)$ is synthesized entirely in software.

Similarly, in Eq. (18), the input term $\Delta V(s) = V_1(s) - V_2(s)$ denotes the net differential equivalent terminal voltage applied to the Electronic Speed Controllers (ESCs). The gain parameters K_1 and K_2 correspond to the lumped static voltage-to-torque conversion factors ($K_{\text{equivalent},1}$ and $K_{\text{equivalent},2}$) derived from the steady-state characterization ($\tau(t) = K_{\text{equivalent}} V(t)$), effectively mapping the controller output $U(s)$ into duty cycle commands.

The characteristic polynomial of the linearized system yields two distinct, real negative poles. To establish an analytical baseline, the classic open-loop Ziegler–Nichols (ZN) tuning methodology was applied. These initial parameter values, consolidated in Table 4, served as the starting baseline configuration evaluated during the preliminary simulation stage.

Table 4: Initial Ziegler–Nichols baseline parameters for the PID controller

Control Framework	K_p	K_i	K_d
Voltage Proportional	1.495	2.889	0.129
Virtual Current	0.641	0.155	0.664

5.3 Adaptive Hybrid Fuzzy-PID Control Design

To enhance tracking robustness against parameter variations and unmodeled non-linear dynamics, an adaptive hybrid Fuzzy-PID controller is synthesized. Unlike classical structures with fixed parameters, the proposed architecture updates the proportional (K_p), integral (K_i), and derivative (K_d) gains in real-time. The block topology uses a Mamdani-type Fuzzy Inference System (FIS) acting as an online tuning mechanism over the nominal parallel baseline gains (K_{p0}, K_{i0}, K_{d0}) established in Table 4.

The real-time adaptation mechanism is mathematically governed by three dimensionless multiplicative scaling vectors ($\alpha_p, \alpha_i, \alpha_d$), defined as follows:

$$K_p(t) = \alpha_p(t) K_{p0} \quad (19)$$

$$K_i(t) = \alpha_i(t) K_{i0} \quad (20)$$

$$K_d(t) = \alpha_d(t) K_{d0} \quad (21)$$

The FIS operates via two continuous crisp inputs: the tracking position error $e(t) = \theta_{\text{ref}}(t) - \theta(t)$ and its discrete finite-difference derivative $\dot{e}(t)$. Both input domains are mapped into three linguistic variables: Negativo (N), Zero (Z), and Positivo (P). The internal cross-coupled heuristic knowledge base consists of 9 linguistic IF-THEN rules deduced empirically from simulation behaviors, structured to minimize oscillations while accelerating transient recovery. The uniform rule base is consolidated in Table 5.

Table 5: Heuristic rule base for the adaptive Fuzzy-PID inference system

Error (e)	Derivative ($\dot{e}$)	α_p	α_i	α_d
N	N	Medium	Low	High
N	Z	Medium	Medium	Medium
N	P	Medium	Low	High
Z	N	Low	Medium	High
Z	Z	Medium	Medium	Medium
Z	P	Low	Medium	High
P	N	Medium	Low	High
P	Z	Medium	Medium	Medium
P	P	Medium	Low	High

Note: N: Negative; Z: Zero; P: Positive.

To balance computational efficiency and smooth interpolation boundaries across the operational space, four-parameter trapezoidal membership functions $\mu(x) = [x_1, x_2, x_3, x_4]$ are implemented for the output channels. The physical constraints and explicit boundary coordinates assigned to each linguistic output region are summarized in Table 6.

Table 6: Membership function coordinates for the fuzzy scaling outputs

Output	Region ^a	[$\mathbf{x}_1$; $\mathbf{x}_2$; $\mathbf{x}_3$; $\mathbf{x}_4$]
$\alpha_p \in [0; 1]$	L	[0.10; 0.10; 0.20; 0.30]
	M	[0.20; 0.40; 0.60; 0.80]
	H	[0.70; 0.85; 1.00; 1.00]
$\alpha_i \in [0.3; 1.5]$	L	[0.30; 0.50; 0.60; 0.80]
	N	[0.75; 0.82; 1.18; 1.26]
	H	[1.18; 1.25; 1.42; 1.50]
$\alpha_d \in [0; 1]$	L	[0.095; 0.171; 0.280; 0.370]
	M	[0.370; 0.420; 0.550; 0.640]
	H	[0.640; 0.710; 0.820; 1.000]

^aThe abbreviations represent the fuzzy linguistic regions: Low (L), Medium (M), Normal (N), and High (H).

The aggregated fuzzy outputs are mapped back into crisp real-time correction factors using the standard center-of-gravity defuzzification method. This adaptive structure is seamlessly wrapped around both the equivalent voltage distribution loop and the virtual current loop to compare transient performance bounds under identical physical excitations.

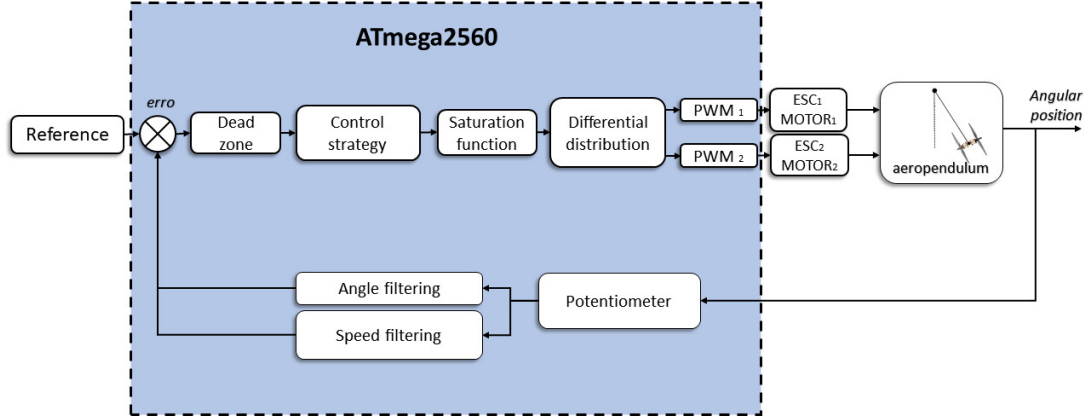


Fig. 3: Real-time signal flow and operational block diagram of the embedded control loop execution.

6 Experimental Results and Discussion

This section presents the experimental performance analysis of the twin-rotor aeropendulum under four distinct operational conditions angular step references, evaluated both with and without external disturbances. In each scenario, the classical parallel PID and the adaptive hybrid Fuzzy-PID controllers are comprehensively benchmarked under both equivalent voltage and virtual current actuation frameworks.

6.1 Experimental Parameters and Signal Flow Architecture

The baseline parameters obtained during the simulation stage served as the initial state for the physical embedded system. However, during real-time deployment, minor empirical adjustments were required to compensate for physical motor asymmetries, structural measurement noise, and aerodynamic non-linearities.

The discrepancy between simulation and experimental parameters is primarily attributed to the current actuation framework. While the analytical model considers the armature current directly via the torque constant (K_t), the physical microprocessor outputs a digital PWM duty cycle

proportional to the estimated variable. To bridge this gap and coordinate the physical experiments, a unified execution architecture was developed within the processing unit. The operational signal flow governing this real-time implementation is mapped in Fig. 3.

The finalized controller parameters utilized throughout the experimental campaign are consolidated in Table 7. The heuristic fuzzy rules and output boundaries established in Section 3 remained unaltered, with gain tuning managed in real-time via the developed supervisory graphical user interface.

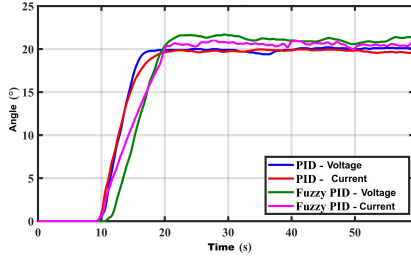
Table 7: Final controller parameters applied during the experimental verification

Controller Architecture	K_p	K_i	K_d
PID – Voltage Framework	5.00	10.00	0.200
PID – Virtual Current Framework	0.05	0.03	0.009

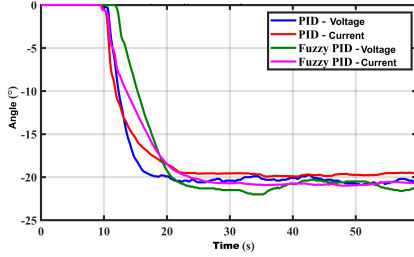
Note: Base Fuzzy-PID scaling parameters equal the conventional PID gains.

6.2 Transient Tracking under Step References ($\pm 20^\circ$)

To evaluate the tracking capability and operational symmetry of the architectures, a $\pm 20^\circ$ step reference was commanded at $t = 10$ s from a steady state of repose. The resulting angular displacement trajectory is illustrated in Fig. 4, while the corresponding control efforts are shown in Fig. 5. Additionally, Table 8 provides a quantitative comparison of the time-domain performance metrics, steady-state errors, integrated error indices (IAE, ISE, ITAE), and cumulative control efforts (ISSC).



(a) Positive step reference ($+20^\circ$).

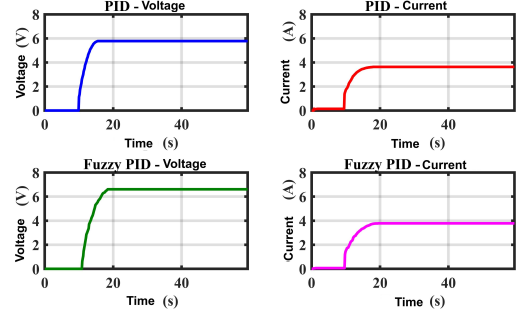


(b) Negative step reference (-20°).

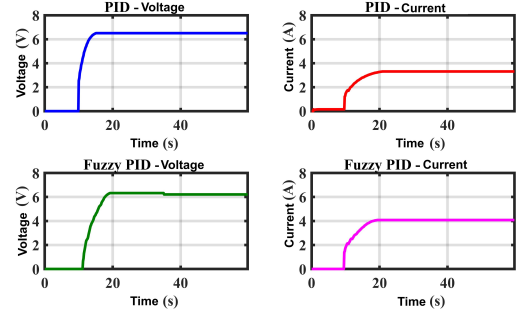
Fig. 4: Experimental tracking under step references.

6.3 Disturbance Rejection under Step References ($\pm 20^\circ$)

The system's resilience and recovery capability were tested by introducing an external physical disturbance after the aeropendulum reached its steady-state operating point. The dynamic angular response under this perturbed condition is captured in Fig. 6, whereas the control signals dispatched during the stabilization process are



(a) Positive step ($+20^\circ$).



(b) Negative step (-20°).

Fig. 5: Real-time control effort signals dispatched to the propulsion units under step references.

detailed in Fig. 7. To validate these transient behaviors, Table 9 consolidates the perturbed performance metrics, error indices, and energetic control expenditures (ISSC).

6.4 Comparative Analysis and Discussion

The experimental evaluation exposes dynamic and energetic distinctions between the equivalent voltage and estimated current actuation frameworks across both reference directions, under both nominal tracking and perturbed conditions.

6.4.1 Nominal Step Reference Response

Under disturbance-free step tracking, the voltage-driven PID controller consistently achieved the fastest initial acceleration, yielding the shortest rise times across both reference directions with minimal overshoot and steady-state error. This responsive behavior indicates a faster initial

Table 8: Combined transient performance metrics, integrated error indices, and energetic control efforts under step references

Setpoint	Actuation	Controller	Temporal metrics				Integral Indices			
			M_p (%)	t_r (s)	t_s (s)	e_{ss} (°)	IAE	ISE	ITAE	ISSC
+20°	Voltage	PID	0.50	4.78	37.39	0.10	66.05	746.64	940.03	1571.73
	Voltage	Fuzzy-PID	1.67	6.77	55.02	1.34	134.32	1263.10	2957.58	1966.19
	Current	PID	1.90	6.10	18.54	0.40	79.83	845.22	1214.70	624.77
	Current	Fuzzy-PID	2.67	8.76	50.07	0.49	114.67	1104.99	2089.93	663.74
−20°	Voltage	PID	2.78	4.51	54.83	0.33	69.79	726.48	1288.53	2040.42
	Voltage	Fuzzy-PID	2.51	7.66	53.74	1.46	127.79	1201.39	2851.11	1758.59
	Current	PID	2.23	7.25	40.96	0.50	81.82	705.85	1407.05	508.89
	Current	Fuzzy-PID	1.71	9.30	25.06	0.64	118.34	1070.72	2358.39	775.60

Table 9: Combined transient performance metrics, integrated error indices, and energetic control efforts under external disturbance

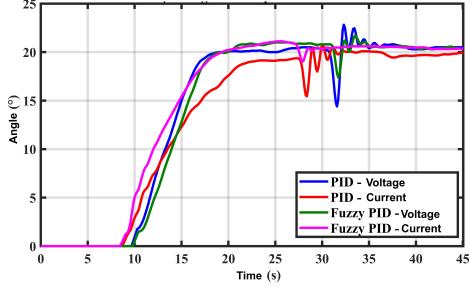
Setpoint	Actuation	Controller	Temporal metrics				Integral Indices			
			M_p (%)	t_r (s)	t_s (s)	e_{ss} (°)	IAE	ISE	ITAE	ISSC
+20°	Voltage	PID	11.32	6.01	34.78	0.50	83.34	860.66	1361.15	1077.17
	Voltage	Fuzzy-PID	6.25	6.13	34.91	0.44	95.43	1014.02	1540.62	1229.09
	Current	PID	4.80	10.55	31.46	0.17	121.95	1312.82	1787.31	420.18
	Current	Fuzzy-PID	3.85	7.60	28.37	0.34	86.59	790.55	1293.62	387.40
−20°	Voltage	PID	0.41	8.62	33.33	1.31	95.07	930.59	1714.04	927.79
	Voltage	Fuzzy-PID	3.77	7.35	38.23	1.00	112.51	1111.36	2138.56	1152.40
	Current	PID	0.50	12.79	33.08	0.23	117.62	1013.72	1862.83	283.40
	Current	Fuzzy-PID	1.62	10.42	31.05	0.36	131.05	1297.67	2346.54	597.79

dynamic response associated with direct voltage actuation. However, this rapid start demands severe actuator aggression, resulting in the highest control efforts observed in the entire nominal test. This high energetic activity indicates a more aggressive control action that imposes significant physical demands on the motor-ESC propulsion modules.

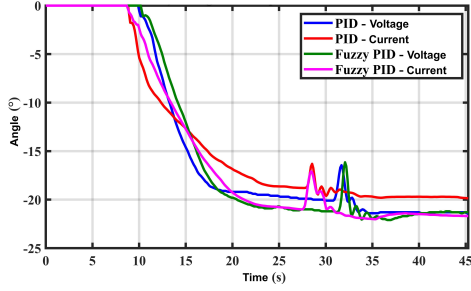
Conversely, the estimated current loop smooths this initial transient. Although it introduces slightly longer rise times, this framework dramatically optimizes the settling time, most notably for the positive step reference. Concurrently, the electrical stress is drastically attenuated, resulting in a substantial reduction in control energy expenditure. This phenomenon confirms the primary advantage of the current-driven paradigm: by embedding the linear

current-to-torque relationship directly within the control software, the system successfully minimizes the non-linearities, saturation effects, and thrust asymmetries typical of commercial propulsion units.

The advantages of the proposed virtual current loop become even more prominent when paired with the intelligent Fuzzy-PID controller. For the positive step trajectory, shifting from voltage to current actuation causes a drop in all integrated performance and error indices. A similar behavior is observed for the negative step reference, where the current-loop cascade mapping significantly reduces the settling time while slashing the overall energetic effort. These results demonstrate that combining fuzzy logic with a current-driven framework provides a more damped, highly stable, and energy-efficient dynamic response.



(a) Positive step reference ($+20^\circ$) under external disturbance.



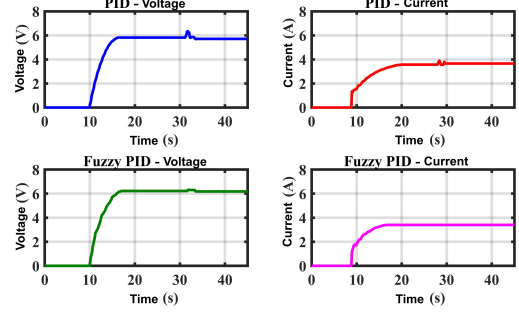
(b) Negative step reference (-20°) under external disturbance.

Fig. 6: Experimental angular displacement tracking performance under positive and negative step references with external disturbances.

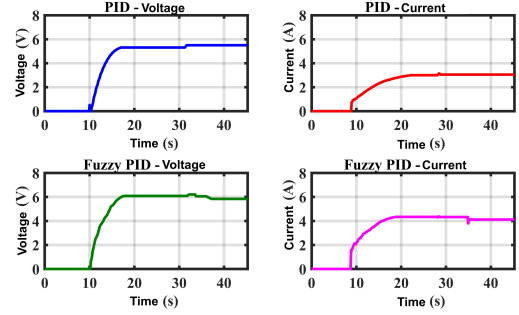
6.4.2 External Disturbance Rejection and Robustness

When subjected to external physical disturbances, the current-driven loop demonstrates superior robustness and predictability over the voltage-driven framework, which suffered from high sensitivity and excessive control effort. Under voltage actuation at the positive step reference, the conventional PID reached the highest overshoot of the entire study. Although the Fuzzy-PID controller successfully mitigated this peak, it suffered from degraded integral error indices and a prolonged settling time.

In contrast, the estimated current loop significantly fortified the system against external impacts. For the positive operating point, the current-driven PID achieved a lower overshoot, a faster settling time, and excellent steady-state precision, while drastically slashing the control effort compared to its voltage counterpart. The



(a) Control effort during positive step ($+20^\circ$) disturbance recovery.



(b) Control effort during negative step (-20°) disturbance recovery.

Fig. 7: Real-time control effort signals dispatched to the propulsion units during disturbance rejection and recovery.

absolute best overall performance at this setpoint was achieved by the current-driven Fuzzy-PID, which successfully paired exceptionally low integral error indices with the minimum energetic footprint among all tested configurations, representing superior disturbance rejection and high energy efficiency.

For the negative reference, however, a distinct performance boundary was observed. Here, the current-driven conventional PID achieved the most balanced response, yielding a minimized overshoot, outstanding steady-state accuracy, and the absolute lowest global control effort of all disturbance trials. Conversely, the current-driven Fuzzy-PID experienced a noticeable performance degradation, characterized by a consistent rise in both the integrated error criteria and the energetic effort, alongside a significant increase in the steady-state error. This behavior suggests that for

this specific operating zone, the membership functions or rule base of the fuzzy inference system were sub-optimal, leading to control degradation compared to the simpler, conventional PID.

7 Conclusion

This paper presented the development of a compact aeropendulum testbed to experimentally evaluate the impact of low-level actuation on aerospace control systems. The primary contribution consisted in comparing a conventional equivalent voltage-driven scheme against a virtual estimated current-loop, under both classical PID and hybrid Fuzzy-PID control.

The nominal experimental trials demonstrated that the proposed virtual current loop successfully linearizes the actuation channel, mitigating the non-linearities and thrust asymmetries characteristic of commercial motor-ESC propulsion units. When subjected to external disturbances, this current-driven paradigm proved robust, maintaining outstanding steady-state precision while drastically reducing control effort. Although the current-driven Fuzzy-PID scheme established the optimal performance-to-energy trade-off at positive operating points, a distinct operational boundary was observed at negative setpoints; in this latter regime, the conventional PID coupled with virtual current actuation emerged as the most balanced and reliable strategy.

Supplementary information.

Acknowledgements. ?

Declarations

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An appendix contains supplementary information that is not an essential part of the text itself but which may be helpful in providing a more comprehensive understanding of the research problem or it is information that is too cumbersome to be included in the body of the paper.

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